

Peer Response

by [Abdulla Husain Salem Hadna Almessabi](#) - Friday, 31 October 2025, 8:03 PM
Hi Abdulrahman,

The case of Dark Patterns you have analysed is informative and successfully relates the ACM and BCS codes to the ethical aspects of dishonest design. I concur with your argument that such manipulative design decision-making is in contravention of the major principles of the ACM, especially the one that advocates the cause of the populace (1.1) and the one that avoids harm (1.2). The designers manipulate user autonomy and destroy trust, which is essential in honesty and fairness (1.3), by guiding users to more expensive or inadvertent choices.

The way you have connected this to the BCS Code of Conduct (2022) and its focus on serving the interests of the public and being upright is also something that I like. The two codes are categorical about deceptive manipulation. Ethically, this type of practice is more of an exploitation rather than an innovation, and, as you mentioned, the practice may be violating the principles of fairness and transparency of the UK GDPR (MacLure, MacLure, Levy, and Dearing, 2022).

Another aspect that should be mentioned is that dark patterns not only harm the consumer but also destroy the professional reputation of computing practitioners. ACM Principle 3.3 states that professionals must guarantee ethical design systems and reduce the possible harm before their implementation (Carey, 2018). Not only is transparent, user-centred design a legal requirement, but it is also a consumer-facing aspect that is imperative according to the need to maintain trust among the population in the use of technology.

Very good post on the convergence of ethics, law and design integrity.

References

ACM (2018) ACM Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct. New York: Association for Computing Machinery. Available at: <https://www.acm.org/code-of-ethics> (Accessed: 1 November 2025).

Carey, P., 2018. Data protection: a practical guide to UK and EU law. Oxford University Press, Inc..

MacLure, K., MacLure, A., Levy, S. and Dearing, W., 2022. Characterising the health and social care segment of the BCS (The Chartered Institute for IT) membership and their continuing professional development needs. *BMJ Health & Care Informatics*, 29(1), p.e100504.

Information Commissioner's Office (2023) A guide to the data protection principles (UK GDPR, Article 5). Available at: <https://ico.org.uk> (Accessed: 1 November 2025).

Peer Response

by [Aneta Worku](#) - Sunday, 2 November 2025, 6:29 PM

This case shows how important honesty and fairness are in web design. Making design changes that push users toward more expensive options is misleading and goes against both ethical and legal standards.

According to the ACM Code of Ethics (ACM, 2018), designers must work for the public good and avoid harm (1.1, 1.2). That means they should not use tricks or “dark patterns” that confuse users or cause them to spend more without real consent.

Designers also need to be honest (1.3) and test their systems to make sure they do not take advantage of anyone (2.5) (Song et al., 2012).

The BCS Code (BCS, 2022) supports the same values by requiring fairness, integrity, and respect for users’ rights. Designers should clearly explain options, treat users with respect, and protect their data privacy. Misleading designs not only damage trust but can also break laws like the UK GDPR which demands fairness and transparency when handling personal data (Seckler et al., 2015).

To act ethically, the design team should remove any deceptive elements, provide simple and clear options, and document the risks involved. Good design should empower users, not manipulate them. A useful test would be to ask, “Would I feel comfortable defending this design to users or regulators?” If not, it needs to change (Parsons, 2021).

Reference list:

ACM (2018) ACM Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct. New York: Association for Computing Machinery. Available at: <https://www.acm.org/code-of-ethics> [Accessed: 1 November 2025].

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Parsons, H. (2021) How to defend your design decisions. Available from: <https://medium.com/design-bootcamp/how-to-defend-your-design-decisions-b864de424d2f> [Accessed 2 November 2025]

Seckler, M., Heinz, S., Forde, S., Tuch, A.N. and Opwis, K., 2015. Trust and distrust on the web: User experiences and website characteristics. *Computers in human behavior*, 45, pp.39-50. Available from: Trust and distrust on the web: User experiences and website characteristics - ScienceDirect [Accessed 1 November 2025]

Song, R., Li, B., Wu, X., Liu, C. and Qi, S. (2012) December. A preference and honesty aware trust model for web services. In 2012 19th Asia-Pacific Software Engineering Conference. Available from: A Preference and Honesty Aware Trust Model for Web Services | IEEE Conference Publication | IEEE Xplore [Accessed 2 November 2025].

Peer Response

by [Rayyan Mohamed Abdalla Alshambeeli Alnaqbi](#) - Monday, 3 November 2025, 7:04 PM
Hello, Abdulrahman

You have brought to light important moral and professional concerns regarding manipulative design decisions, commonly referred to as "dark patterns." These strategies blatantly violate important ACM values, especially transparency, honesty, and regard for user welfare. Users' informed consent is violated and trust is damaged when they are directed toward more expensive or unexpected options. In a similar vein, the BCS Code upholds designers' obligations to behave honorably, respect privacy, and serve the public interest. Fairness and transparency are further emphasized by legal frameworks like consumer protection laws and the UK GDPR, which means that misleading designs run the risk of breaking both ethical and legal requirements. Removing any deceptive interface elements, documenting potential risks, and guaranteeing user control through explicit, opt-in options are the responsible courses of action. In the end, ethical design fosters enduring trust and harmonizes corporate objectives with user well-being, a position that can be justified by both users and regulators.

References:

- ACM (2018) *Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct*. Available at: <https://www.acm.org/code-of-ethics> (Accessed: 3 November 2025).
- BCS (2022) *BCS Code of Conduct*. Available at: <https://www.bcs.org/membership/become-a-member/bcs-code-of-conduct/> (Accessed: 3 November 2025).